Case Title

Analysis of Suspicious Email Impersonating Tax Authority (SARS)

Objective

To analyze a suspicious email claiming to be from the South African Revenue Service (SARS) and determine whether it is legitimate or part of a phishing or fraud attempt.

Case Background

On **16 April 2026**, an email was received in the spam folder claiming to be from the South African Revenue Service.

The email referenced an **"Outstanding Settlement Notification"** and included a PDF attachment.

Initial suspicion was raised due to:

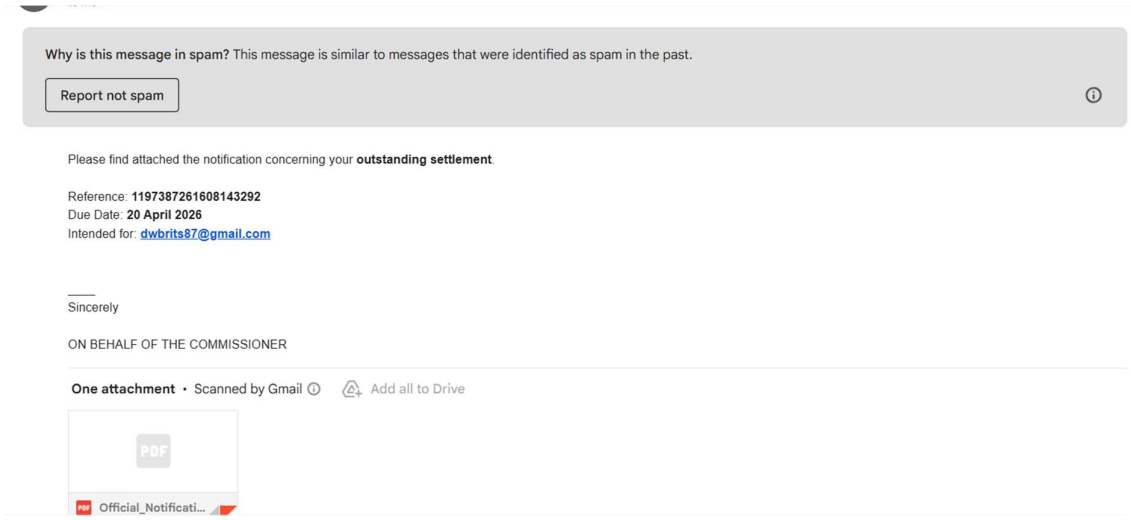
- The timing of the email (outside expected tax communication periods)
- The presence of an attachment
- Generic and urgent financial language

Evidence Collected

Exhibit 1 – Email Overview (Header Summary)

Message ID	<0fb4258a75f6cd5fa12ef9b2b5e8f264@sars-ita.ovh>
Created at:	Thu, Apr 16, 2026 at 8:26 PM (Delivered after 4 seconds)
From:	South African Revenue Service <sars-action@sars-ita.ovh>
To:	dwbrits87@gmail.com
Subject:	Outstanding Settlement Notification for dwbrits87@gmail.com
SPF:	PASS with IP 46.105.34.251 Learn more
DKIM:	'PASS' with domain sars-ita.ovh Learn more
DMARC:	'PASS' Learn more

Exhibit 2 – Email Body Content



Why is this message in spam? This message is similar to messages that were identified as spam in the past.

Report not spam

Please find attached the notification concerning your **outstanding settlement**.

Reference: **1197387261608143292**
Due Date: **20 April 2026**
Intended for: **dwbrits87@gmail.com**

Sincerely

ON BEHALF OF THE COMMISSIONER

One attachment • Scanned by Gmail Add all to Drive

PDF

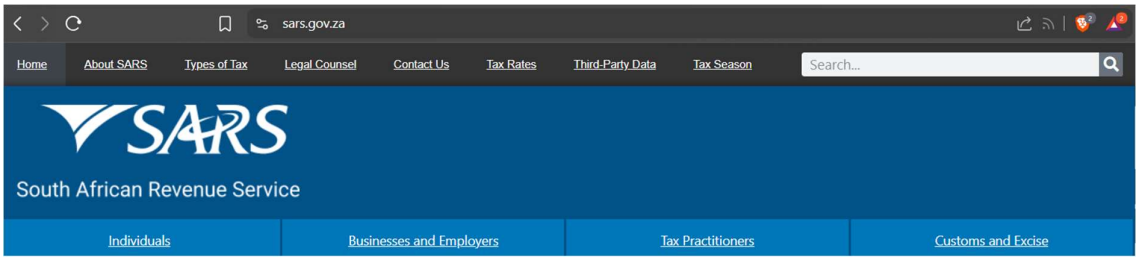
Official_Notificati...

Exhibit 3 – Full Email Header (Raw Data)

```
Delivered-To: dwbrits87@gmail.com
Received: by 2002:a05:6402:b37:b0:672:a15d:5a7f with SMTP id bo23csp10706edb;
        Thu, 16 Apr 2026 11:26:20 -0700 (PDT)
X-Received: by 2002:a05:6214:3f83:b0:8ac:dd87:b5b2 with SMTP id 6a1803df08f44-8b025dc0fbfmr5750346d6.11.1776363980469;
        Thu, 16 Apr 2026 11:26:20 -0700 (PDT)
ARC-Seal: i=1; a=rsa-sha256; t=1776363980; cv=none;
        d=google.com; s=arc-20240605;
        b=Xfjq+RLVGQe44YmF/qoPHXPzrqKEuOhKVyUUmBXhe3iLvO0i2ZC6hkPPm+wH1KLpuA
         skwVhSgpfiMiokSbVhmyeG3fSWd3G+0CqMG+nI8LCizC5Dh4TckFumH9Z5eNiXH5HJRE
         QkjnZwsEq3/WziZihwIKq0Rezv12nbkjsZgqueCrIcYt3cIGJLHKfAInraYKLimWYR5t
         i9Tz9QfVXHqOja/qomTAXZGrCg7onSnsxHpBtBUFL48ju3f4/umHkfQM90j0zILtbVEp
         mJ5RGNeo9Mx2N9JCKF/ZvS4RlmEvZ1QPPr4u8Mpsit862HD5Eeclr+pMVl17030MO6GA
         Pgwg==
ARC-Message-Signature: i=1; a=rsa-sha256; c=relaxed/relaxed; d=google.com; s=arc-20240605;
        h=dkim-signature:date:mime-version:message-id:reply-to:subject:to
         :from;
        bh=56vy2ot/AIFf8/PKF3xdneMbpG5vYnfvwwuPnnkDUxY=;
        fh=TNvVFWv20HqpEZ2TfMolVMRqQvYhKFrL0wdgRgZd0qg=;
        b=QfvELRS0CGtLq4mPr72UnpdIAA3VolZb54iU3x7sv3pnlOwqtVSzL4AGrJkg3urRy8
         nTJRT0TnrY533TQRbSCRvnzfo3v7vJUVUsOyrRZW7bqZIUL4jzSyg5oDVUC6oP14YhTd
         NxFY8LD9OtrxmzP8o6uJ/GsxxxxZ4WeOQsVVXJRVBc+VpII2M5KR9GriQvgYbJ9W0b6D
         gYZloO4O6UDFbj7ZCw3gZDeBGlwBqQSrwGpYoNG8jEMcAfK3gckmG/A1PyzAp91o8dpF
         yo0VDwCKUDYeaMIBL3FkDaRh9zwMJO8r1+bVEEKLU2iQDv51uOX6lkWTkc2ND5uRJaH7
         GYUQ==;
        dara=google.com
ARC-Authentication-Results: i=1; mx.google.com;
       dkim=pass header.i=@sars-ita.ovh header.s=ovhemp1232078-selector1 header.b=iEBI7nXG;
       spf=pass (google.com: domain of sars-action@sars-ita.ovh designates 46.105.34.251 as permitted sender) smtp.mailfrom=sars-action@sars-ita.ovh;
       dmarc=pass (p=NONE sp=NONE dis=NONE) header.from=sars-ita.ovh
Return-Path: <sars-action@sars-ita.ovh>
Received: from mo528.mail-out.ovh.net (smtpout1.mo528.mail-out.ovh.net. [46.105.34.251])
        by mx.google.com with ESMTPS id 6a1803df08f44-8ae6cec7c5dsi88490976d6.380.2026.04.16.11.26.19
        for <dwbrits87@gmail.com>
        (version=TLS1_3 cipher=TLS_AES_256_GCM_SHA384 bits=256/256);
        Thu, 16 Apr 2026 11:26:20 -0700 (PDT)
Received-SPF: pass (google.com: domain of sars-action@sars-ita.ovh designates 46.105.34.251 as permitted sender) client-ip=46.105.34.251;
Authentication-Results: mx.google.com;
       dkim=pass header.i=@sars-ita.ovh header.s=ovhemp1232078-selector1 header.b=iEBI7nXG;
       spf=pass (google.com: domain of sars-action@sars-ita.ovh designates 46.105.34.251 as permitted sender) smtp.mailfrom=sars-action@sars-ita.ovh;
       dmarc=pass (p=NONE sp=NONE dis=NONE) header.from=sars-ita.ovh
Received: from director2.derp.mail-out.ovh.net (director2.derp.mail-out.ovh.net [79.137.60.36]) by mo528.mail-out.ovh.net (Postfix) with ESMTPS id
4fxRKk1pLMz5vqd for <dwbrits87@gmail.com>; Thu, 16 Apr 2026 18:26:18 +0000 (UTC)
Received: from director2.derp.mail-out.ovh.net (director2.derp.mail-out.ovh.net. [127.0.0.1])
        by director2.derp.mail-out.ovh.net (inspect_sender_mail_agent) with SMTP
```

```
        for <dwbrits87@gmail.com>; Thu, 16 Apr 2026 18:26:18 +0000 (UTC)
Received: from pro2.mail.ovh.net (unknown [10.109.254.150]) by director2.derp.mail-out.ovh.net (Postfix) with ESMTPS id 4fxRKk0bdwz1xr3 for
<dwbrits87@gmail.com>; Thu, 16 Apr 2026 18:26:18 +0000 (UTC)
Received: from [127.0.0.1] (162.0.233.181) by DAG20EX2.emp2.local (172.16.2.202) with Microsoft SMTP Server (version=TLS1_2,
cipher=TLS_ECDHE_RSA_WITH_AES_256_GCM_SHA384) id 15.2.2562.37; Thu, 16 Apr 2026 20:26:16 +0200
From: South African Revenue Service <sars-action@sars-ita.ovh>
To: <dwbrits87@gmail.com>
Subject: Outstanding Settlement Notification for dwbrits87@gmail.com
Reply-To: <pop@sarscollections.com>
Message-ID: <0fb4258a75f6cd5fa12ef9b2b5e8f264@sars-ita.ovh>
MIME-Version: 1.0
Date: Thu, 16 Apr 2026 18:26:16 +0000
Content-Type: multipart/mixed; boundary="HOg4l7Lq"
X-Originating-IP: [162.0.233.181]
X-ClientProxiedBy: CAS10.emp2.local (172.16.1.10) To DAG20EX2.emp2.local (172.16.2.202)
DKIM-Signature: v=1; a=rsa-sha256; d=sars-ita.ovh; s=ovhemp1232078-selector1; c=relaxed/relaxed; t=1776363978; h=from:to:subject:date;
bh=56vy2ot/AIFf8/PKF3xdneMbpG5vYnfvwwuPnnkDUxY=;
b=iEBI7nXG+Ga0oYgTM4GJoILASrS8FCVji8kUCyWo61FRiFCtUdRPGaz1Go/t/DwEo59uFzK/YiXsif1nc1Fj4z32LBDcSmxxnjA93u0SRQWFmyp2PHvAxWR7aVYl2dfhDaFIjo65QZADC59ZCR1o
uV6TC4aqp+JVqXJ8gJ1PCMtjfZApnjAfjx93NDcYY04B4C59VXmJeWbO4PRn7bRAWyEDlNrczKJKk2RmCFDPnwvY+wI8gnZCI4sN2RypHGM+c27Ri+CKwJqx3MR/O3V/KApyZiTjxpHr5dgqudZmip
XvGKP/eNUA9xy0FUPmD30eXSr+m7Xo9XjqW3SuqaluQ==
x-ovh-tracer-id: 3011219302400644475
X-VR-SPAMSTATE: OK
X-VR-SPAMSCORE: 0
X-VR-SPAMCAUSE:
dmFkZTGKLQvN4d78l7lCw8Kgz0/Uzfkbi8F8kn3SPKyG75lnCKrZC7uYtvrALDXmBH84ABLrIkYXAc+YyHQDtJ9FzGegI4ANebhN+Ey+DqfdQS9QS3s6qlKQDc9JTlcO6Be876f+DJ7++4FrWGxpLq
05aftQYEliayAaM6AprERfjYLalnkqlXSZAhd6tQwdfAAKkbb+qFqiRXF/pz5PbpAA6uBiFNG8cDDoEk+PdDEcH6u6PY5TOPTWraR5JYNus+9JDxOUXe2hJVyRtfFADFcROJ0jq0zp3JvQuXt8WWk4
AomnbrQomZVdpO9yhLoNlH0gljEmFvRCgqQCHAKnnMrIVmdtcsewkuNbTLKRvx6P9e0huLrhVV+ciAZWKqrPNSFCECoBJdVMZTI+0oIzUKUC9HRHjSiiux6CZyIaXuKCFGmTx+HkMldi84Q4B+gaVo
1uDtKTNTKJQqsVxOfF9btux2xMHtolyzVprFa7c+fTMTHMei8cr6kNoXrfTo/6PGJtutAq7igoy2QiaFNjE5PmhucdnUrE1le5TdvT0UQRGdAN3bEh+JsEpzggkv73nU9FPH7b/uU7ZCf9c/sL1TIz
E2AeYQUsu52lCixPO0yToiymaBTEQHhHTRBtKdcxCiLnJcm6iIsZpzVWO/pI9C3sh+Z+UOaB0BCrtSmEQdL09ZSanw

--HOg4l7Lq
Content-Type: multipart/alternative; boundary="1R7WWPK7"

--1R7WWPK7
Content-Type: text/plain; charset="utf-8"
Content-Transfer-Encoding: quoted-printable

Please find attached the notification concerning your outstanding settlemen=
t.

Reference: 1197387261608143292
Due Date: 20 April 2026
Intended for: dwbrits87@gmail.com
```


Exhibit 4 – Official Domian



Analysis

1. Sender Domain Analysis

- **From Address:** sars-action@sars-ita.ovh
- **Reply-To Address:** pop@sarscollections.com

Official Domain Reference

The legitimate domain used by the South African Revenue Service is:

- **@sars.gov.za**

Key Observations

- The sender domain (sars-ita.ovh) does **not match** the official SARS domain
- The .ovh domain is associated with **commercial hosting providers**, not government infrastructure
- The Reply-To domain (sarscollections.com) is **completely different** from both:
    - The sender domain
    - The official SARS domain

Assessment

This discrepancy between:

- The **official domain (sars.gov.za)**
- The **sender domain (sars-ita.ovh)**
- The **reply-to domain (sarscollections.com)**

is a **strong indicator of domain impersonation**, a common tactic used in phishing attacks.

2. Email Authentication Results

- SPF: Pass
- DKIM: Pass
- DMARC: Pass (policy = NONE)

Interpretation:

Although authentication checks passed, this **does NOT confirm legitimacy**.

Reason:

- Attackers can configure authentication on **malicious domains they control**
- DMARC policy is set to **NONE**, meaning no strict enforcement

Conclusion:

Authentication alone is **not sufficient for trust**

3. Infrastructure Analysis

- Sending server associated with:
    - ovh.net (hosting provider)
- Originating IP:
    - 162.0.233.181

Key Insight:

Legitimate government agencies like SARS typically:

- Use **controlled government infrastructure**
- Do not rely on generic hosting providers for official notices

This further supports **fraudulent origin**

4. Content Analysis (Social Engineering Indicators)

The email contains:

- Generic language:
  - "Outstanding settlement"
- Urgency:
  - Due date: **20 April 2026**
- Lack of personalization:
  - No name, only email address
- Authority impersonation:
  - "ON BEHALF OF THE COMMISSIONER"

These are **classic phishing tactics**

5. Timing Analysis

The email was received in **April 2026**, while:

- SARS tax-related communications typically occur during **official tax season periods**

This inconsistency raises **additional suspicion**

6. Attachment Risk Assessment

- The email includes a PDF attachment:
    - Official_Notification.pdf

Risk Indicators:

- Unexpected attachment from unknown sender
- Financial urgency combined with attachment
- Common phishing delivery method

Attachments in such emails often:

- Contain malware
- Or redirect to credential harvesting pages

Findings

The email is assessed to be a **phishing attempt** impersonating the South African Revenue Service.

Key Indicators:

- Fake sender domain (sars-ita.ovh)
- Mismatched Reply-To address
- Use of third-party mail infrastructure

- Generic and urgent language
- Suspicious attachment
- Timing inconsistent with official communication

Confidence Level

- **High**
- The presence of multiple independent indicators strongly supports the conclusion that this email is fraudulent.

Limitations

- The attachment was not executed or opened in a sandbox environment
- No malware analysis was performed on the PDF
- Analysis is based on header data and content review only

Tools Used

- Email header analysis
- Manual OSINT techniques
- Pattern recognition and phishing indicators

Analytical Summary

- This case demonstrates how phishing emails can appear technically valid through passing authentication checks while still being malicious. By analyzing domain legitimacy, infrastructure, message content, and behavioral indicators, it is possible to accurately identify fraudulent communications.

Skills Demonstrated

- Email header analysis
- Phishing detection
- OSINT investigation
- Infrastructure analysis
- Social engineering identification
- Risk assessment